Ashfaqulla Khan — Research Dossier

Research only | 1757–1947 freedom struggle archive | Compiled 21 October 2026

Reading key: each entry gives the fact or claim | clickable source link | exact short quote. Quotes belong to their sources; a source reporting a story does not automatically prove that the story happened. LATER RETELLING, ATTRIBUTED MEMORY and UNSURE are used where evidence is incomplete. Historical robbery and an unintended death are described without praise.

1. Basic facts

Full name and other names

Name: Ashfaqulla Khan (also written Ashfaq Ullah Khan / Ashfaqullah Khan) | Source 5 | “Ashfaqulla Khan (22nd October, 1900 – 19th December, 1927)”

Name form in the National Book Trust account: Ashfaq Ullah | Source 1 | “Ashfaq Ullah was born on 22 October 1900”

Possible poetry pen names: Warsi and Hasrat; spellings conflict | Source 6 | “pen-names of ‘Warsi‘ and ‘Hasrat’” (UNSURE; see Section 4)

Birth and death

Born: 22 October 1900, Shahjahanpur | Source 1 | “Ashfaq Ullah was born on 22 October 1900 in the city of Shahjahanpur”

Died: 19 December 1927, Faizabad jail; executed by hanging | Source 5 | “put to death by hanging on 19 December, 1927, at Faizabad jail” (The NBT book also accidentally gives 1929 elsewhere; see Section 4)

Family, education, work

Father: Shafiq Ullah; described as a landowner | Source 1 | “His father Shafiq Ullah was a Zamindar and had five children.”

Mother: called Mazhoor-Un-Nisa Begum by a memorial organisation | Source 6 | “His mother Mazhoor-Un-Nisa Begum was an extremely pious lady.” (Source is a later memorial, not a reproduced birth record)

Elder brother: Riyasat Ullah Khan, according to memorial account | Source 6 | “His elder brother Riyasat Ullah Khan was a class mate of Pandit Ram Prasad Bismil.” (LATER RETELLING)

Primary education at home, later attended Abbie Rich Mission High School | Source 1 | “he was admitted to Abbie Rich Mission High School in Shahjahanpur.”

Reported school expulsion connected to non-cooperation activities | Source 1 | “he was expelled from the school by the head master.” (LATER RETELLING; school register not verified)

Later worked as a clerk at an engineering firm in Daltonganj | Source 1 | “He got a job as a clerk in an engineering firm at Daltonganj in Palamau District.” (LATER RETELLING; employment record not opened)

Groups and organisations

Hindustan Republican Association (HRA): revolutionary organisation associated with him | Source 5 | “In 1924, Ashfaqulla Khan formed an organization with like-minded freedom fighters which was named Hindustan Republican Association.”

HRA, not HSRA, is the contemporary name used by a newspaper history for the 1925 action | Source 4 | “the Hindustan Republican Association’s (HRA) first major action in 1925.” (Some later sources incorrectly use the later name; see Section 4)

Took part in activities of the Indian National Congress during the Non-Cooperation period | Source 1 | “he continued to take part in the activities of the Congress.” (Formal party membership not established)

Ten events in date order

1920–21 — Reported participation in non-cooperation work with Ram Prasad Bismil | Source 1 | “During the Non-Cooperation Movement in 1920-21 they went to several villages” (LATER RETELLING)

February 1922 — Non-Cooperation Movement called off; later biographies connect this to Ashfaqulla’s path | Source 1 | “he called off the Non-Cooperation Movement in February 1922.” (Motive inferred by later biography)

1924 — Hindustan Republican Association established | Source 5 | “In 1924, Ashfaqulla Khan formed an organization”

1 January 1925 — HRA manifesto, Krantikari, released | Source 4 | “Their manifesto released on January 1, 1925, was titled Krantikari (Revolutionary).”

9 August 1925 — Kakori train robbery; government cash taken | Source 2 | “the most sensational train dacoity on August 9, 1925 after 7 p. m.”

11 August 1925 — Police report registered two days after robbery | Source 8 | “It was lodged on August 11, 1925, two days after the incident”

1925–26 — Ashfaqulla avoided capture and reportedly worked in Daltonganj | Source 1 | “he went to Bihar. He got a job as a clerk” (LATER RETELLING; precise dates not verified)

1926 — Arrest reported in Delhi; exact date disputed: July 17 or December 7 | Source 3 | “Ashfaqullah Khan was arrested on 7 December 1926 at Delhi.” (UNSURE; see Section 4)

1927 — Separate supplementary Kakori trial with Sachindra Nath Bakshi | Source 2 | “Ashfaqullah and Sachindra Nath Bakshi, were arrested and tried in a supplementary trial”

11 August 1927 — Appeals were decided; death penalty confirmed | Source 2 | “their lengthy judgment dated August 11, 1927 upheld the findings” (This source concerns appeals in both trials)

19 December 1927 — Executed at Faizabad jail | Source 5 | “hung on 19 December, 1927, at Faizabad jail.”

2. Story angles (at least 10)

Each is a possible research-led short story, not a completed story. A hook is a question, not an additional historical claim.

01. The Boy Asked to Leave School

Could taking part in a movement cost a pupil his place in class?

> **A later account says he was expelled for political activity** | Source 1 | “he was expelled from the school by the head master.” [LATER RETELLING]

02. The Brother Who Talked About Poetry

How might stories told by an older brother lead to a new friendship?

> **The local memorial names an elder brother who knew Bismil** | Source 6 | “His elder brother Riyasat Ullah Khan was a class mate of Pandit Ram Prasad Bismil.” [FAMILY MEMORY, narrator not identified]
>
> **The memorial says Riyasat talked about Bismil** | Source 6 | “Riyasat used to tell his younger brother Ashafaq about the bravery and shayari Urdu poetry of Bismil.” [LATER RETELLING]

03. A Poet With Two Names

Why would someone write poems under a name different from their own?

A memorial gives two pen names | Source 6 | “pen-names of ‘Warsi‘ and ‘Hasrat’” [Spellings conflict with National Book Trust]

04. A Shared Dish

Did two friends of different faiths really eat from the same dish?

A later biography describes the shared utensil | Source 1 | “they had their meals in the same utensil.” [UNVERIFIED LATER RETELLING]

The account also gives Ashfaqulla’s name for Bismil | Source 1 | “Ashfaq used to address Bismil as ‘Ram’.” [UNVERIFIED LATER RETELLING]

05. The One-Word Pamphlet

What was printed in a political manifesto before the Kakori action?

An HRA manifesto appeared in January 1925 | Source 4 | “Their manifesto released on January 1, 1925, was titled Krantikari (Revolutionary).” [Newspaper historical account]

06. Three Second-Class Tickets

Why did three travellers buy tickets together at Kakori station?

A later report says Bakshi bought the tickets | Source 10 | “Bakshi purchased three second-class tickets from Kakori station” [LATER RETELLING / Bakshi account]

07. Who Pulled the Chain?

Why do descriptions of one small action name two different people?

A Bakshi-centred account identifies Bakshi | Source 10 | “Bakshi pulled the train’s emergency chain” [LATER RETELLING]

Indian Express account identifies Lahiri | Source 4 | “Rajendranath Lahiri, a member of the HRA who was already seated inside, pulled the chain and stopped the train.” [DISPUTED]

08. The Hammer and the Cash Box

What happened when the safe would not open?

A later National Book Trust narrative describes a hammer | Source 1 | “broke the strong metal box with a hammer” [LATER RETELLING]

Court history identifies the location of the safe | Source 2 | “they then broke open the safe in the brake van” [COURT HISTORY]

09. The Passenger Named Ahmad Ali

Who died during the train robbery, and what do records say?

Court history names the passenger | Source 2 | “hit and killed a lawyer Ahmad Ali” [COURT HISTORY]

A government broadcaster attributes the shot to one participant | Source 3 | “was killed by a bullet fired by Manmathnath Gupta.” [AKASHVANI HISTORICAL ACCOUNT]

10. The Urdu Page in a Police Station

What can a surviving page tell us, and where did the original go?

The police complaint was originally in Urdu | Source 8 | “Its original FIR was written in Urdu.” [CONTEMPORARY DOCUMENT DESCRIBED IN NEW REPORT]

A police official says the original location is unknown | Source 8 | “We do not know where the original copy is” [ATTRIBUTED TO SHO NAWAB AHMAD]

11. A Reward Notice in an Old Newspaper

Why did the authorities offer more money than some reports say was stolen?

A newspaper reports a reward notice | Source 9 | “announced a bounty of Rs 5,000” [REPORTED FROM PERIOD NEWSPAPERS]

The same article identifies one newspaper issue | Source 9 | “Hamdam dated Aug 27, 1925” [NEWSPAPER ARCHIVE MENTION]

12. Food at Night in a Sugarcane Field

Where did Ashfaqulla hide while police searched?

A later biography places him in a sugarcane field | Source 1 | “concealed himself in a sugarcane field half a mile away from his home.” [LATER RETELLING]

It says friends sent food at night | Source 1 | “his friends used to send him food only at night.” [LATER RETELLING]

13. The Clerk Who Said He Was From Mathura

How could a person who was wanted by police work at an engineering company?

The biography records a clerk’s job | Source 1 | “He got a job as a clerk in an engineering firm at Daltonganj” [LATER RETELLING]

It also describes a false home village | Source 1 | “He pretended to be hailing from a farmer’s family in Mathura” [LATER RETELLING]

14. Poems After Work

How did poetry enter the story of an engineering office?

A later biographer describes an employer who liked verse | Source 1 | “The proprietor of the firm in which Ashfaq worked was very fond of shers.” [LATER RETELLING]

15. A Meeting in Delhi

What happened after he trusted someone he had known from home?

A later biography mentions a Pathan acquaintance | Source 1 | “he went to Delhi and met a Pathan friend from Shahjahanpur” [LATER RETELLING]

Congress account says a classmate informed police | Source 5 | “This friend, in turn, betrayed him by informing the police” [LATER RETELLING; arrest date disputed]

16. Two Trials in the Same Case

Why did Ashfaqulla and Bakshi face a different judge?

Court history records the second trial | Source 2 | “tried in a supplementary trial by Mr. J. R. W. Bennett” [LEGAL HISTORY]

It records their different sentences | Source 2 | “Ashfaqullah to death and Sachindra Nath Bakshi to transportation for life” [LEGAL HISTORY]

17. Different Sentences, One Journey

What did Bakshi remember about their different punishments?

A newspaper identifies Bakshi’s memoir | Source 10 | “In his memoir ‘Kranti Ke Path Par’, Bakshi recalled his trial with Ashfaqullah Khan.” [LATER MEMORY BY BAKSHI]

The report names the two prisons | Source 10 | “Ashfaqullah was sent to Faizabad Jail for execution” [LATER MEMORY]

18. A Diary From a Cell

Can an attributed diary be connected to an original manuscript?

A memorial reproduces purported prison writing | Source 7 | “While he was confined in the solitary cell of Faizabad Jail, he started writing a diary.” [ATTRIBUTED DIARY; ORIGINAL NOT VERIFIED]

The memorial reproduces a line attributed to him | Source 7 | “Only for the love of our country I suffer so much.” [ATTRIBUTED WORDS]

19. The Last Walk — Two Retellings

What can later accounts tell us about a day when no checked eyewitness transcript survives?

National Book Trust describes a bag containing a Quran | Source 1 | “with a copy of the holy Quran in it” [LATER RETELLING]

Another newspaper describes reciting the Kalma | Source 11 | “he tied the Quran on his chest, and recited the ‘Kalma’.” [LATER RETELLING; exact wording may depend on punctuation]

Flagship story — “The Urdu Page in a Police Station” (Angle 10). It is anchored to a physical record, a definite filing date, a language detail and a still-unresolved question about the missing original. The story can teach children how evidence survives imperfectly. Its key claims come from reporting on a police document rather than from a reconstructed speech. Secondary candidates are the hammer and cash box (Angle 8; later retelling) and the two different sentences (Angle 16; documented by court history).

3. People and places connected

Shafiq Ullah Khan — Father; described as a landowner | Source 1 | “His father Shafiq Ullah was a Zamindar”

Mazhoor-Un-Nisa Begum — Mother, named by local memorial | Source 6 | “His mother Mazhoor-Un-Nisa Begum”

Riyasat Ullah Khan — Elder brother in later account | Source 6 | “His elder brother Riyasat Ullah Khan”

Ram Prasad Bismil — Fellow HRA member and poet | Source 4 | “Ram Prasad Bismil and Ashfaqulla Khan, both of whom had a flair for poetry”

Sachindra Nath Bakshi — Fellow defendant in supplementary Kakori trial | Source 2 | “Ashfaqullah and Sachindra Nath Bakshi”

Rajendra Nath Lahiri — Kakori participant; executed on 17 December 1927 | Source 4 | “December 17 (Rajendranath Lahiri)”

Thakur Roshan Singh — One of four men executed following Kakori case | Source 4 | “Thakur Roshan Singh”

Ahmad Ali — Passenger killed in Kakori action | Source 2 | “killed a lawyer Ahmad Ali”

Manmathnath Gupta — Named by Akashvani as person whose shot killed Ali | Source 3 | “bullet fired by Manmathnath Gupta”

J. R. W. Bennett — Judge in supplementary trial | Source 2 | “Mr. J. R. W. Bennett”

Shahjahanpur — Birthplace | Source 1 | “in the city of Shahjahanpur”

Kakori — Railway station near train robbery | Source 2 | “after it left Kakori Railway Station”

Lucknow — City near Kakori, location of judicial process | Source 2 | “8 miles from Lucknow”

Daltonganj, Palamau district — Reported engineering-office workplace | Source 1 | “at Daltonganj in Palamau District”

Delhi — City of his reported arrest | Source 3 | “arrested on 7 December 1926 at Delhi”

Faizabad jail — Place of execution | Source 5 | “at Faizabad jail”

Hindustan Republican Association — Political group linked to the plan | Source 4 | “Hindustan Republican Association (HRA)”

Kakori action — The 9 August 1925 robbery | Source 2 | “train dacoity on August 9, 1925”

4. Disputes, legends and doubts

A. Arrest date — UNSURE

Congress: 17 July 1926 | Source 5 | “on the morning of 17 July, 1926, police came to his house and arrested him.”

Akashvani: 7 December 1926 | Source 3 | “Ashfaqullah Khan was arrested on 7 December 1926 at Delhi.”

Assessment: Two published accounts give different dates. Until arrest registers are checked, do not choose one.

B. Amount taken from the train — UNSURE

Court history: Rs 4,553-3-6 | Source 2 | “Rs. 4, 553-3-6”

Police complaint reported by Hindustan Times: Rs 4,601, 15 annas and 6 pies | Source 8 | “The amount of loot was mentioned as 4601 rupees, 15 anna and 6 pie.”

Indian Express summary: about Rs 4,600 | Source 4 | “approx Rs 4,600”

Assessment: The approximate modern summary is not an independent exact sum; the recorded totals differ. Old notation is rupees, annas and pies. Do not present a single precise amount.

C. Who pulled the train chain — UNSURE

Bakshi narrative: Bakshi | Source 10 | “Bakshi pulled the train’s emergency chain”

Indian Express account: Lahiri | Source 4 | “Rajendranath Lahiri, a member of the HRA who was already seated inside, pulled the chain and stopped the train.”

Assessment: The publications identify different people. Both newspaper accounts are later retellings and differ on who took this action.

D. Execution year printed incorrectly in one book

National Book Trust page 33: 1927 | Source 1 | “It was the dawn of 19 December 1927.”

Same National Book Trust book, page 39: 1929 | Source 1 | “Ashfaq Ullah was hanged on 19 December 1929 in the Faizabad jail.”

Congress: 1927 | Source 5 | “hung on 19 December, 1927, at Faizabad jail.”

Assessment: The 1929 line conflicts with the same book and other sources. Record it as an internal source error, not a second accepted timeline.

E. The group name in 1925

Congress article sometimes says HSRA | Source 5 | “the revolutionaries of HSRA, including Ram Prasad Bismil”

Indian Express names the 1925 group HRA | Source 4 | “the Hindustan Republican Association’s (HRA) first major action in 1925.”

Indian Express dates the HSRA name later | Source 4 | “In 1928, this new grouping became the Hindustan Socialist Republican Association (HSRA).”

Assessment: Use HRA for 1925. The other name is an anachronism in some later writing, but preserve source differences.

F. Poetry pen names

National Book Trust: Varsi and Hazrat | Source 1 | “His pen names were Varsi and Hazrat.”

Local memorial: Warsi and Hasrat | Source 6 | “pen-names of ‘Warsi‘ and ‘Hasrat’”

Assessment: Spellings differ in both words. Do not treat variations as settled without examining Urdu originals.

G. How Ashfaqulla and Bismil first met

National Book Trust: at school | Source 1 | “he met the famous revolutionary Ramprasad Bismil, who was then studying in ninth class”

Local memorial: at a public meeting in 1922 | Source 6 | “Ashfaq ullah met him in a public meeting”

Assessment: Both are later retellings without original class or meeting records verified here. The memorial also incorrectly says non-cooperation began in 1922.

H. Reported final words — LATER RETELLINGS

National Book Trust account | Source 1 | “shouted Khuda Hafiz (adieu).”

Times of India account from author Salman Shahjahanpuri | Source 11 | “he tied the Quran on his chest, and recited the ‘Kalma’.”

Assessment: The accounts cannot establish verbatim last words. Neither is a contemporary transcript verified in this research.

I. The temple confrontation — UNVERIFIED LATER RETELLING

National Book Trust narrative | Source 1 | “Ashfaq took out his revolver”

Assessment: The tale describes a confrontation at an Arya Samaj temple but no independently opened contemporary police, temple or eyewitness record confirms it. Do not assert the dialogue as recorded fact.

J. Diary, letters and prison conversations — ATTRIBUTED MEMORY

Memorial claims prison diary | Source 7 | “he started writing a diary.”

Times of India refers to Bakshi’s memoir | Source 10 | “In his memoir ‘Kranti Ke Path Par’, Bakshi recalled his trial”

Assessment: Exact prison dialogue and diary quotations require manuscript or edition checks. Label such material as attributed accounts.

K. Number of people in initial police complaint

First police account: 20–25 unidentified people | Source 8 | “20-25 unidentified people robbed the amount.”

Akashvani later account: ten revolutionaries | Source 3 | “a group of 10 young revolutionaries executed a daring plan”

Assessment: An early unverified suspect count is not the same as a later participant list; do not silently combine the numbers.

5. Pictures

Only photographs with Commons file pages stating public-domain status in India and the United States are listed. Date is the Commons file description, not the upload date. These images are linked to their file pages; claimed identification or date may not be independently authenticated.

Undated portrait of Ashfaqulla Khan

What it shows: Described as Ashfaqulla Khan, photographed circa 1920s
Date as stated: Circa 1920s
License on page: Public domain in India and United States.
Commons file page: Source 14
Exact description: “An undated photo of Ashfaqulla Khan”

Ashfaqulla Khan at Faizabad jail (uploader's identification)

What it shows: A portrait described by the Commons uploader as taken while imprisoned; identification context not independently verified
Date as stated: Before 1927
License on page: Public domain in India and United States.
Commons file page: Source 15
Exact description: "photo of Ashfaqulla Khan while he was in Faizabad jail"

Second undated portrait of Ashfaqulla Khan

What it shows: A different Commons photograph record of Ashfaqulla Khan
Date as stated: Circa 1920s
License on page: Public domain in India and United States.
Commons file page: Source 16
Exact description: "An undated photo of Ashfaqulla Khan"

Portrait of Ram Prasad Bismil

What it shows: Black-and-white image of Ashfaqulla's HRA associate
Date as stated: No later than 1927
License on page: Public domain in India and United States.
Commons file page: Source 17
Exact description: "Ram Prasad Bismil, Indian revolutionary, poet & writer (1897-1927)"

Excluded: Modern stamps, monuments, recent commemorative pictures and unverified scans are not treated as period photographs. No photo is presented as a proven image of the execution.

6. Sources used

Every numbered entry below opens the exact source page used in the fact and story-angle sections. Click the title or any Source number above.

1. Hanged for Patriotism, R. K. Tandon (2009) — National Book Trust, India

2. History of the Court in Avadh from 1856 A.D. up to Present Time, H. K. Ghose — Allahabad High Court (hosted legal history)

3. Parikrama — Kakori Train Action segment (2025) — Akashvani / News on AIR, Government of India

4. How young revolutionary leaders executed the Kakori Train Robbery (2023) — The Indian Express

5. Ashfaqulla Khan (1900–1927) (2020) — Indian National Congress, Congress Sandesh

6. Early Life — Ashfaq Ullah Khan — Ashfaq Ullah Khan Memorial Shaheed Shodh Sansthan, Faizabad

7. Few Words from Ashfaq's Diary — Ashfaq Ullah Khan Memorial Shaheed Shodh Sansthan, Faizabad

8. Kakori FIR copy: Priceless page from the past (2024) — Hindustan Times

9. British bounty lure in Kakori action was more than loot amount itself (2025) — The Times of India

10. Bijnor jail Smritika preserves memories of Kakori unsung hero (2025) — The Times of India

11. The brave die once, cowards daily: Ashfaq (2016) — The Times of India

12. A Ram Prasad Bismil revolutionary poet (2023) — The Indian Express

13. Who was Ashfaqullah Khan? (2020) — The Indian Express

14. Ashfaqulla Khan 2619.JPG — Wikimedia Commons

15. Ashfaqulla Khan in Faizabad jail.jpg — Wikimedia Commons

16. Ashfaq Ulla Khan (2).JPG — Wikimedia Commons

17. Ram Prasad Bismil portrait (file: Bismil901.gif) — Wikimedia Commons